

# FLASHPOINT

**POLESTAR INSIGHTS**

REPORTING PERIOD: 18 MAY 2026 - 24 MAY 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This briefing covers the activism, protest and civil-unrest picture across 18 May 2026 - 24 May 2026. The detailed operational read, country breakdown, forecast and analyst sections follow below.

FAST FACTS

|                                                                    |                                                                                   |                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <div>REPORTING PERIOD</div> <div>18 May - 24 May 2026</div>        | <div>RECORDS IN WINDOW</div> <div>18</div> <div>13 activism, 2 civil unrest</div> | <div>HIGHEST SEVERITY</div> <div>High</div> <div>Worst rating in window</div> |
| <div>TOP ISSUE TYPE</div> <div>Protest</div> <div>11 records</div> | <div>MOST AFFECTED COUNTRY</div> <div>Pakistan</div> <div>9 records</div>         | <div>LATEST INCIDENT</div> <div>23 May 2026</div>                             |

ACTIVISM AND PROTEST READ

The activism picture across the briefing window (18 May - 24 May 2026) is anchored on protest reporting, with "Opposition lawmakers stage protest in National Assembly, demand medical care for Imran" as the lead entry. The mix breaks down as protest (9), strike / labour action (3) and student activism (1).

For operators, the practical read is that named opposition movements, sectoral unions and student bodies remain the primary drivers of street-level disruption. Roads, transport hubs and city-centre commercial districts are the typical pressure points; staff movement, last-mile logistics and customer-facing footfall are the first surfaces to feel the effect.

ACTIVISM RECORDS

| DATE        | ISSUE                  | TITLE                                                                                                        | SEVERITY |
|-------------|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 23 May 2026 | Protest                | PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release                                                               | HIGH     |
| 22 May 2026 | Protest                | PTI workers stage protests in various cities, defy Section 144 in Islamabad                                  | HIGH     |
| 21 May 2026 | Protest                | Imran's cases will be fixed after Eid, CJP assures PTI                                                       | MODERATE |
| 20 May 2026 | Protest                | Afridi, Aleema claim shots were fired at Adiala sit-in participants                                          | HIGH     |
| 20 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | Chemists strike on May 20: Why Indian pharmacists are protesting e-pharmacies over rules, pricing and safety | HIGH     |
| 19 May 2026 | Protest                | Over 200 protesting metro bus employees demand salaries in Rawalpindi                                        | MODERATE |
| 19 May 2026 | Student activism       | Teachers protest abduction of Gwadar University VC, others                                                   | MODERATE |
| 19 May 2026 | Protest                | TTAP, PTI announces countrywide protests on Friday against Imran's imprisonment, rising inflation            | HIGH     |
| 18 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | (2nd LD) Court mostly grants Samsung Electronics' injunction request against union strike                    | MODERATE |

| DATE        | ISSUE                  | TITLE                                                                                                                | SEVERITY |
|-------------|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 18 May 2026 | Protest                | Bhopal 'dowry death': Twisha Sharma's kin protests in front of MP CM's house; seeks AIIMS post-mortem   What we know | MODERATE |
| 18 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | (LEAD) Court partially accepts Samsung Electronics' injunction request against union strike                          | MODERATE |
| 18 May 2026 | Protest                | JI emir challenges petroleum levy in FCC, terms it 'unconstitutional'                                                | HIGH     |

## CIVIL UNREST AND PUBLIC ORDER READ

Civil unrest in the briefing window (18 May - 24 May 2026) carries a highest severity of low, led by "4 courthouse rioters get suspended terms for attacking reporters".

The composition is dominated by riot / public disorder (2).

Operationally, crackdowns and curfew orders matter more than the headline protest count: they signal where the state is prepared to escalate enforcement and where staff movement, commercial operations and venue access can be disrupted at short notice. Where security-force operations cluster around a single city or district, expect rolling road closures and intermittent connectivity.

## CIVIL UNREST RECORDS

| DATE        | ISSUE                  | TITLE                                                            | SEVERITY |
|-------------|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 18 May 2026 | Riot / public disorder | 4 plead guilty to rioting during 2019 PolyU siege in Hong Kong   | LOW      |
| 18 May 2026 | Riot / public disorder | 4 courthouse rioters get suspended terms for attacking reporters | LOW      |

## FORECAST: NEXT 7-14 DAYS

| COUNTRY     | SIGNAL                               | OPERATIONAL MEANING                                                                         |
|-------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pakistan    | PTI mobilisation for Imran's release | Road closures and venue-access friction around party HQs, court complexes and city centres. |
| India       | Chemists' strike notice              | Pharmacy supply disruption 24-72h ahead; brief procurement and customer-care.               |
| Pakistan    | Sectoral pay protest                 | Sectoral walkout risk; brief logistics and field operations on local delays.                |
| Pakistan    | Faculty / campus protest             | Campus action seeds city-centre protests within a week; expect adjoining-road disruption.   |
| South Korea | Union injunction ruling              | Sectoral disruption pending court ruling; pre-position contingency supply.                  |
| India       | Family-led protest                   | Localised protest at official premises; brief venue security and visitor management.        |

Confirmed forward-looking items are listed in the table above and should be the first reference points for the next 7-14 days. The trajectory commentary below sits behind that scheduled calendar.

Across the next 7-14 days, Pakistan is likely to remain the leading source of activism and civil-unrest reporting on current cadence, with 9 records on file this cycle. Adjacent cities and university campuses are possible secondary flashpoints.

Activism reporting dominates the current mix, so the most likely escalation path is from announced rallies and sectoral walkouts into intermittent road closures and city-centre disruption. Risk increases if security forces respond with mass arrests, tear gas or curfew orders; risk eases if organisers stand down voluntarily or political talks open.

Cautious read: a thin cycle is not a sustained easing in these geographies. A single political event can repopulate the file inside 48 hours, so the forecast should be treated as a baseline rather than a prediction.

REGIONAL AND COUNTRY VIEW

Across the briefing window the file leans on Pakistan with 9 records against 3 for China and 3 for India.

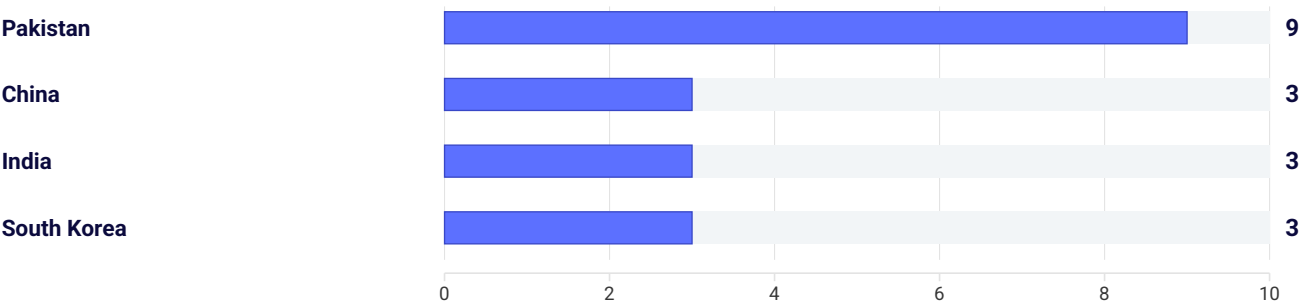
Pakistan - 9 records, driven by protest alongside student activism. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main disruption loci: university campuses, adjoining road networks and exam-board administrative offices.

China - 3 records, driven by protest alongside other operational incident. Likely form: announced rallies and sectoral walkouts that routinely draw a visible enforcement response; main disruption loci: city-centre commercial districts, transport hubs and government precincts.

India - 3 records, driven by protest alongside strike / labour action. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main disruption loci: wholesale markets, transport corridors and sectoral premises (pharmacies, courts, hauliers).

A further 1 country carry low-volume entries; see chart below.

RECORDS BY COUNTRY



WHAT MATTERS

The cycle's centre of gravity sits with Pakistan, which carries 9 records across the activism and civil-unrest mix. That matters operationally because protest cadence in Pakistan routinely converts into rolling road closures, intermittent connectivity disruption and pressure on staff movement at short notice.

Activism reporting (13) running alongside civil-unrest reporting (2) is the classic pattern when announced rallies are routinely met with police orders, selective detentions and tear-gas dispersal. The risk profile sits in the second-order response: curfew impositions, internet shutdowns and mass arrests usually follow a single high-visibility incident rather than a slow build.

IMPLICATIONS FOR BUSINESS

- Review staff movement plans and journey-management routings across Pakistan against the live protest calendar.
- Set clear work-from-home or delayed-start triggers for offices, plants and customer-facing sites in affected cities.
- Confirm alternative routes for staff, visitors and delivery movements around courts, ministries, campuses and party offices.
- Harden site access controls, perimeter checks and visitor restrictions; pre-position guard reinforcement.
- Pre-approve staff, customer and regulator communications for disruption days so messages move in minutes, not hours.
- Monitor Section 144 / curfew orders, arrests, injuries and any internet-shutdown notices in cities of operation.

- Wire procurement, distribution and customer-service into the security early-warning feed - sectoral walkouts and campus calls lead street action by 24-72 hours.

## WATCH NEXT

- Pakistan - PTI mobilisation for Imran's release: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- India - Chemists' strike notice: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- Pakistan - Sectoral pay protest: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- Pakistan - Faculty / campus protest: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- South Korea - Union injunction ruling: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- India - Family-led protest: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.

## POLESTAR VIEW

Mobilisation capacity across Pakistan is non-trivial this cycle, drawing on named-movement organising (6), sectoral chamber and union action (6) and student and campus mobilisation (1) - multiple independent vectors, harder to contain than a single-issue wave.

Speed of escalation looks measured, but the runway is short - historically 24-72 hours from a peaceful announced rally to a kinetic incident once a political trigger lands.

Likely protest geography over the next 7-14 days: Pakistan (9 records) sets the tempo and China (3) is the most likely secondary flashpoint. Expect clustering around court complexes, party HQs, ministry quarters, campuses and main commercial arteries.

Business disruption risk over the next window is moderate-to-elevated: short-notice transport disruption on protest days, public-facing site closures driven by Section 144 / curfew orders, and supply-chain friction from sectoral walkouts. The residual tail is a triggering event - adverse ruling, fuel-price decision, security-force fatality - flipping the cycle into sustained unrest.

## RELATED INCIDENTS

| DATE        | ISSUE                  | TITLE                                                                                                        | SEVERITY |
|-------------|------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| 21 May 2026 | Protest                | Imran's cases will be fixed after Eid, CJP assures PTI                                                       | MODERATE |
| 20 May 2026 | Strike / labour action | Chemists strike on May 20: Why Indian pharmacists are protesting e-pharmacies over rules, pricing and safety | HIGH     |
| 23 May 2026 | Protest                | PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release                                                               | HIGH     |
| 22 May 2026 | Protest                | PTI workers stage protests in various cities, defy Section 144 in Islamabad                                  | HIGH     |
| 20 May 2026 | Protest                | Afridi, Aleema claim shots were fired at Adiala sit-in participants                                          | HIGH     |
| 19 May 2026 | Protest                | TTAP, PTI announces countrywide protests on Friday against Imran's imprisonment, rising inflation            | HIGH     |

## SOURCE NOTES / DATA NOTES

5 kinetic armed-conflict records without a public-order hook were excluded so the read stays focused on activism, protests and civil unrest. 1 court-only legal-process record without a civil-unrest hook were excluded. 1 syndicated duplicate was collapsed via two-pass title and topic-signature dedupe.

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